

HeyGen Complete Guide

Step-by-Step Tutorial

How to Create Professional AI Avatar Videos

For WavesAI Academy Course Recording

Appendix to Video Recording Scripts Guide

[Screenshot: /tmp/heygen-home.png]

1. What is HeyGen?

HeyGen is an AI video generation platform that creates professional talking-head videos using digital avatars. Instead of recording yourself on camera, you choose an avatar, type your script, and HeyGen produces a realistic video of the avatar speaking your words.

Key features:

- 200+ realistic AI avatars (diverse ages, ethnicities, styles)
- 300+ voices in 40+ languages
- Custom avatar creation from your own photo or video
- Text-to-video in minutes (no camera, no editing skills needed)
- API access for automated video generation at scale
- Multiple backgrounds, templates, and customisation options
- 1080p and 4K video output

Use cases for your AI business:

- Client training videos and tutorials
- Marketing and social media content
- Sales videos and product demos
- Internal team communications
- Multilingual content (same avatar, different languages)
- Course content and educational material
- Customer onboarding videos

2. Getting Started with HeyGen

Step 1: Create Your Account

1. Open your browser and go to: www.heygen.com
2. Click the "Get Started for Free" button (bright blue button on the homepage)
3. You can sign up with Google (quickest) or enter your email and password
4. If using Google: click "Sign in with Google" and select your Google account
5. If using email: enter your email, create a password, and verify via the confirmation email
6. Once signed up, you'll land on the HeyGen dashboard

NOTE: HeyGen offers 1 free credit on signup. After that, plans start from \$24/month (Creator plan). For this course, we used the API with credits.

Step 2: Explore the Dashboard

Once logged in, you'll see the main dashboard. Here's what each section does:

1. HOME: Your main workspace. Shows recent projects and quick-start options.
2. AVATARS: Browse all available avatars. Filter by gender, ethnicity, style, and outfit.
3. TEMPLATES: Pre-made video templates for different use cases (marketing, education, etc.)
4. VIDEOS: All your generated videos are stored here. Download or share them.
5. BRAND KIT: Upload your logo, brand colours, and fonts for consistent branding.
6. SETTINGS: Account settings, API keys, billing, and team management.

3. Creating Your First HeyGen Video

This is the core tutorial. Follow these steps exactly to create a professional avatar video.

Step 1: Start a New Video

1. From the dashboard, click "Create Video" (top-right corner, blue button)
2. You'll see several options: "Avatar Video", "URL to Video", "PDF to Video", "Template"
3. Select "Avatar Video" - this is the standard talking-head video
4. A new video editor will open with a blank canvas

Step 2: Choose Your Avatar

1. On the left panel, click "Avatar" (person icon)
2. Browse the avatar library. You'll see categories: Studio Avatars, Photo Avatars, Instant Avatars
3. STUDIO AVATARS: These are the highest quality. They have natural body movements and gestures. Recommended for professional content.
4. PHOTO AVATARS: Created from a single photo. Good for personalised content but less natural movement.
5. INSTANT AVATARS: Quick-generate from a photo. Fastest but lowest quality.
6. For professional course content, use STUDIO AVATARS. We used "Brandon" (Business Standing Front) for the academy.
7. Click on an avatar to preview them. You'll see them animate briefly.
8. To select: click on the avatar and they'll appear in your canvas.
9. You can change the avatar's position: full body, half body, or close-up.

PRO TIP: For the academy videos, we used "Brandon_Business_Standing_Front_public" - a professional male avatar in business attire. Choose an avatar that matches your brand's tone.

Step 3: Choose a Background

1. Click "Background" in the left panel (landscape icon)
2. Options: Solid colour, Gradient, Image upload, Video background
3. For professional videos: use a clean solid colour (white, light grey, or your brand colour) or a simple office/studio background
4. To use a solid colour: select "Color" and pick your shade. Enter a hex code for exact brand colours.
5. To upload a custom background: click "Upload" and select your image (1920x1080 recommended)
6. To use a video background: select "Video" and choose a subtle, non-distracting loop
7. You can also use "No Background" (green screen) and add your own in editing software later

PRO TIP: Keep backgrounds simple and professional. A busy background distracts from your message. A solid colour or a slight gradient works best.

Step 4: Write Your Script

1. Click on the text box below the canvas (or click "Script" in the left panel)
2. Type your script. The avatar will speak exactly what you type.
3. Keep scripts between 30 seconds and 3 minutes. Longer scripts take more credits and may lose viewer attention.
4. Write naturally - use contractions (I'm, we'll, don't) and conversational language.
5. Add pauses with "..." (three dots) or commas for natural pacing.
6. For emphasis, use exclamation marks or question marks - the AI adjusts tone slightly.
7. You can use SSML tags for advanced control (see Advanced section below).

Example Scripts for Different Use Cases:

Business Introduction (30 seconds):

"Welcome to WavesTech! We help businesses save time and increase revenue using cutting-edge AI tools. Whether you need automation, content creation, or AI-powered customer service, we've got you covered. Book a free discovery call today and let's transform your business together."

Course Lesson Introduction (45 seconds):

"Welcome to Module 3, Lesson 4! Today we're diving into AI Video Avatars. By the end of this lesson, you'll know how to create professional talking-head videos without ever picking up a camera. I'll walk you through two powerful platforms - HeyGen and D-ID - and show you exactly when to use each one. Let's get started!"

Product Demo (60 seconds):

"Let me show you how our AI automation saves business owners an average of 20 hours per week. First, customer enquiries are automatically answered by our AI chatbot. Second, leads are captured and organised in your CRM without any manual entry. Third, follow-up emails are sent automatically based on each customer's behaviour. The result? More leads, faster responses, and zero busywork. Ready to see it in action? Click the link below to book your free demo."

Step 5: Select a Voice

1. Click "Voice" in the script panel (speaker icon next to the text box)
2. Browse the voice library. Filter by: Language, Gender, Accent, Style
3. For English content, popular voices include: "Confident Connor", "Professional Patricia", "Friendly Fiona"
4. Click the play button next to each voice to preview it with your script
5. For the WavesAI Academy, we used "Confident Connor" (ID: f0e85b4704444baf960bf40da463e57b) - a clear, professional male voice
6. You can adjust: Speed (0.5x to 2x) and Pitch (lower or higher)

7. For courses, use 1x speed or slightly slower (0.9x) so students can follow along
8. Select your preferred voice and close the voice panel

PRO TIP: Match your voice to your avatar. Male avatar = male voice. Also match the energy: a business presentation needs a calm, professional voice, while a social media ad can be more energetic.

Step 6: Preview and Generate

1. Click the "Preview" button to hear a quick audio preview of your script with the selected voice
2. Check for: natural pacing, correct pronunciation, appropriate tone
3. If something sounds off, adjust your script text (add commas for pauses, rephrase awkward sentences)
4. When you're happy with the preview, click "Generate" (or "Submit")
5. The video will enter a processing queue. Generation typically takes 2-5 minutes for a 1-minute video.
6. You'll see a progress indicator. Don't close the browser tab.
7. Once complete, you'll get a notification and the video will appear in your "Videos" section

Step 7: Download Your Video

1. Go to "Videos" in the left navigation (or click the notification)
2. Find your generated video. Click on it to preview.
3. Watch the full video to check quality: lip sync, audio clarity, avatar movements
4. If satisfied, click "Download" (download arrow icon)
5. Choose resolution: 720p (smaller file) or 1080p (recommended for professional content)
6. The video downloads as an MP4 file
7. Rename the file descriptively: "M3-L4-AI-Video-Avatars-Intro.mp4"

4. Advanced HeyGen Features

Multi-Scene Videos

1. In the video editor, you can add multiple scenes (like slides in a presentation)
2. Click the "+" button at the bottom of the timeline to add a new scene
3. Each scene can have a different: avatar, background, script, and voice
4. Use this for longer videos: Scene 1 = Introduction, Scene 2 = Main content, Scene 3 = Summary/CTA
5. You can also insert text overlays, images, and shapes between scenes
6. Drag scenes to reorder them. Each scene generates as one continuous video.

SSML Tags for Voice Control

SSML (Speech Synthesis Markup Language) lets you fine-tune how the avatar speaks. Use these tags in your script:

SSML Tag	What It Does	Example
<code><break time="1s"/></code>	Adds a pause (0.5s, 1s, 2s)	"Hello. <code><break time="1s"/></code> Welcome to the course."
<code><prosody rate="slow"></code>	Changes speaking speed	" <code><prosody rate="slow"></code> This is important. <code></prosody></code> "
<code><prosody pitch="+10%"></code>	Changes pitch (higher/lower)	" <code><prosody pitch="+10%"></code> Exciting news! <code></prosody></code> "
<code><emphasis></code>	Adds emphasis to words	"This is <code><emphasis></code> really <code></emphasis></code> important."
<code><say-as interpret-as="digits"></code>	Reads numbers as digits	"Call <code><say-as interpret-as="digits"></code> 12345 <code></say-as></code> "

Custom Avatar Creation

1. HeyGen allows you to create a custom avatar from your own likeness
2. Go to "Avatars" > "Create Avatar" > "Instant Avatar"
3. You'll need to record a 2-minute video of yourself: face the camera, good lighting, plain background
4. Upload the video. HeyGen processes it and creates your personal avatar.
5. Now you can type any script and YOUR avatar will speak it
6. This is powerful for personal branding - your face, any script, any language
7. Note: Instant avatars are included on Creator plan. Photo avatars are also available (upload a still photo).

PRO TIP: Custom avatars are great for coaches, consultants, and personal brands. Your audience gets the familiarity of seeing you without you needing to record every video.

Multilingual Videos

1. HeyGen supports 40+ languages including: English, Spanish, French, German, Arabic, Hindi, Mandarin, Japanese, Korean, Portuguese, and more
2. To create a video in another language, simply write your script in that language
3. Select a voice that matches the language (filter by language in the voice library)
4. The same avatar can speak any language - lips sync automatically
5. Use case: create one course video in English, then duplicate and translate to Spanish, French, etc.
6. This is a huge selling point for clients who serve international audiences

5. Using the HeyGen API (For Automation)

The HeyGen API lets you generate videos programmatically - without using the web interface. This is what we used to generate all 52 academy videos automatically.

Getting Your API Key

1. Log into HeyGen. Click your profile icon (top-right corner).
2. Go to "Settings" > "API" (or navigate to app.heygen.com/settings)
3. Click "Generate API Key" or copy your existing key
4. Your API key looks like: `sk_V2_XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX`
5. Keep this key secret! Never share it publicly or commit it to public code repositories.
6. Store it securely in a password manager or environment variable

API Video Generation Flow

Here's how the API works, step by step:

1. **GENERATE:** Send a POST request to the API with your avatar, voice, and script. The API returns a `video_id`.
2. **POLL:** Check the video status every 15-30 seconds using the `video_id`. Status goes from "processing" to "completed".
3. **DOWNLOAD:** Once completed, the API provides a download URL. Download the MP4 file.
4. The whole process takes 3-8 minutes per video depending on script length.

API Settings Breakdown

Setting	Value	Description
<code>avatar_id</code>	<code>Brandon_Business_Standing_Front_public</code>	Which avatar to use
<code>avatar_style</code>	<code>normal</code>	Avatar style (normal, circle, closeup)
<code>voice_id</code>	<code>f0e85b4704444baf960bf40da463e57b</code>	Confident Connor voice
<code>input_text</code>	Your script here...	The words the avatar speaks
<code>width</code>	<code>1280</code>	Video width in pixels
<code>height</code>	<code>720</code>	Video height in pixels (720p)

6. Which Modules to Show HeyGen In

HeyGen appears in several modules throughout the course. Here's exactly what to demonstrate in each one:

Module 2, Lesson 32: AI Video & Audio Content

What to show: First introduction to HeyGen - basic video creation

1. Open HeyGen and give a quick tour of the dashboard (30 seconds)
2. Click "Create Video" > "Avatar Video"
3. Select Brandon (or another professional avatar). Point out avatar categories.
4. Type a short 3-sentence business intro script
5. Select "Confident Connor" voice. Play the preview.
6. Click Generate. While waiting (3-5 min), switch to showing ElevenLabs.
7. Come back to show the completed HeyGen video. Play it. React positively.
8. Download the video and show the file.
9. Duration for HeyGen portion: about 5 minutes

NOTE: This is the student's first time seeing HeyGen. Keep it simple and impressive. Don't overwhelm with advanced features.

Module 3, Lesson 45: AI Video Avatars: HeyGen & D-ID

What to show: Deep dive comparison of HeyGen vs D-ID

1. Open HeyGen. This time go deeper:
2. Show the full avatar library - scroll through different categories. Let students see the variety.
3. Pick a different avatar from Lesson 32 so students see multiple options
4. Write a 30-second script. This time show the SSML features: add a <break> tag and a <prosody> tag
5. Show the voice library - filter by language. Preview 3 different voices.
6. Select a voice and generate the video
7. While waiting, switch to D-ID (studio.d-id.com):
8. In D-ID: upload a professional photo, type the same script, generate
9. When both videos are done, play them side by side on screen
10. Point out differences: HeyGen has better lip sync and body movement. D-ID is simpler and faster for quick content.
11. Show HeyGen's custom avatar feature (explain it, show the upload screen)
12. Show the multilingual feature: type the same script in Spanish, generate a preview
13. Duration for this lesson: 12-15 minutes

Module 3, Lesson 46: Short-Form Content Factory

What to show: Batch video production with HeyGen

1. Show how to use ChatGPT to break one long script into 3 short TikTok/Reels scripts
2. Open HeyGen. Create the first short video (20 seconds, vertical format if available)
3. Show how to batch: open 2-3 tabs, start generating videos simultaneously
4. While videos generate, show CapCut for adding captions and music
5. Download all 3 short videos. Open them in CapCut.
6. Add auto-captions to the first video. Customise the style.
7. Export in 9:16 (vertical) format for TikTok/Reels
8. Show the complete workflow: AI writes scripts > HeyGen generates videos > CapCut adds captions > Schedule posting
9. Duration: 10-12 minutes

Module 7, Lesson 73: Build a Social Media Management Agent

What to show: Using HeyGen as part of a client service offering

1. This is the capstone project. Show HeyGen as part of the full content production pipeline.
2. Generate 2-3 short avatar videos for different social platforms
3. Show how to create a client's weekly video content in under 30 minutes
4. Explain pricing: if you charge a client 497/month and HeyGen costs 24/month, that's great margins
5. Show batch production: script 5 videos, generate all 5, download, add captions, schedule
6. This demonstrates the scalability of AI video services
7. Duration for HeyGen portion: about 8 minutes within the larger 20-25 minute lesson

7. HeyGen Pricing Guide

The screenshot shows the HeyGen website header with navigation links: Plattform, Anwendungsfälle, Lernen, Preisgestaltung, Unternehmen, and Organisation. A language selector shows 'DE' and an 'Anmelden' button. The main headline reads 'Flexible Preispläne für jede:n Creator und jedes Team'. Below this, a paragraph states: 'HeyGen ermöglicht über 100.000 Unternehmen, Videos zu erstellen, zu lokalisieren, zu skalieren und gemeinsam daran zu arbeiten – ganz ohne Kamera oder Filmteam. Als G2s Nr.1 der am schnellsten Produkte 2025 ausgezeichnet, machen wir die Videoproduktion so einfach wie nie zu'. At the bottom, there are buttons for 'Für Einzelpersonen' and 'Für Unternehmen', along with a cookie consent banner.

Plan	Price	Credits	Best For
Free	Free	1 video	Testing the platform
Creator	\$24/month	15 min/month	Individual content creators
Business	\$72/month	30 min/month	Small businesses & freelancers
Enterprise	Custom	Unlimited	Large organisations

NOTE: Pricing as of 2025. Check heygen.com/pricing for the latest rates. API credits are purchased separately.

8. Troubleshooting Common Issues

Lip sync looks off

- Use shorter sentences with clear punctuation
- Avoid long compound sentences - break them up with full stops
- Add <break> tags between sections for natural pauses
- Choose a voice that matches the avatar's apparent age and style

Audio sounds robotic

- Write conversationally - use contractions (I'm, we'll, can't)
- Add natural filler words occasionally ("Now," "So," "Actually,")
- Use punctuation for pacing: commas = short pause, full stop = longer pause
- Try different voices - some sound more natural than others

Video generation fails

- Check your credit balance - you may have run out
- Shorten your script if it's very long (over 5 minutes)
- Remove any special characters or emojis from the script
- Try a different avatar - some avatars occasionally have issues
- Wait 5 minutes and try again - HeyGen servers may be busy

Video quality is low

- Make sure you're downloading in 1080p (check download settings)
- Use a clean, simple background - complex backgrounds can reduce quality
- Avoid very long single-take videos - break into scenes
- If using API, set dimensions to 1280x720 or 1920x1080

9. Quick Reference Cheat Sheet

Creating a video in 60 seconds:

1. Go to app.heygen.com > Create Video > Avatar Video
2. Pick avatar > Type script > Select voice > Click Generate
3. Wait 3-5 minutes > Download MP4

Best avatars for business content:

- Brandon (Business Standing Front) - Professional, confident, male
- Anna (Business Sitting) - Professional, approachable, female
- Josh (Casual Standing) - Friendly, relaxed, male
- Sophia (Business Standing) - Authoritative, professional, female

Best voices for English content:

- Confident Connor - Clear, professional, authoritative
- Friendly Fiona - Warm, approachable, conversational
- Professional Patricia - Polished, business-appropriate
- Energetic Eric - Upbeat, engaging, great for marketing

Script length guide:

- 15 seconds = ~40 words (social media hook)
- 30 seconds = ~80 words (short intro or ad)
- 60 seconds = ~160 words (product demo or explainer)
- 2 minutes = ~320 words (tutorial intro or lesson opener)
- 5 minutes = ~800 words (full lesson or presentation)

You're now a HeyGen expert! Go create amazing videos.